

START WITH A LAWFUL, COLD FISH

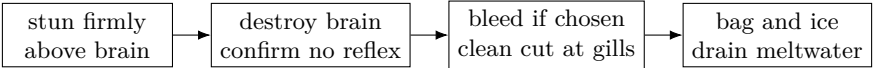
Confirm the live Wisconsin DNR rule and consumption advisory for the exact water, species, length, and date. Kill a retained fish promptly; do not let it suffocate slowly. Bleed only where lawful and practical, then place it in a draining ice slurry or on ice. Keep raw fish at or below 40 °F; wash hands, knife, and board after contact with viscera.

Keep or release?

Legal floor	May 2–Dec 31, 2026 open water; 40-in minimum; daily bag 1 on both lake pages. Check connected-water rules.
Preferred table fish	Only a lawfully harvested fish meeting the controlling minimum; release is normally preferable.
Why	Every legal musky is a large apex predator and breeder; statewide mercury advice is highly restrictive.

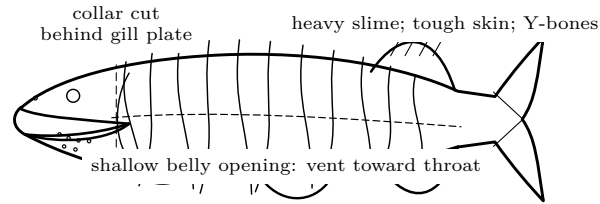
Legal is not the same as desirable. A fish may be lawful yet a poor choice because it is a large breeder, exceeds current meal advice, or cannot be chilled and used promptly.

Dispatch and field care



1. Use a decisive percussive blow to the skull immediately above and just behind the eyes. Follow with a spike or narrow knife into the brain cavity.
2. Confirm loss of rhythmic gill movement and eye reflex. If either remains, repeat immediately. Cut the gill arches only after insensibility.
3. Keep the fish shaded, clean, and cold. Do not soak flesh in warm lake water. At home, work in small batches and return finished portions to ice.

Clean without contaminating the flesh



1. **Set up.** Flexible sharp fillet knife, cut-resistant glove on the non-knife hand, scaler or spoon if needed, pliers, clean towels, two trays.
2. **Scale or skin.** Do not scale. Rinse slime with cold potable water, stabilize the fish, fillet, then skin each slab. Keep the board and knife handle dry enough for control.
3. **Open shallowly.** From vent toward the throat, lift the belly wall away from organs and use the tip only. Remove viscera intact. Avoid puncturing the gall bladder; trim and rinse any contaminated tissue.
4. **Kidney line.** Scrape the dark tissue along the backbone and rinse briefly with clean potable water. Pat dry. Never use soap on food.

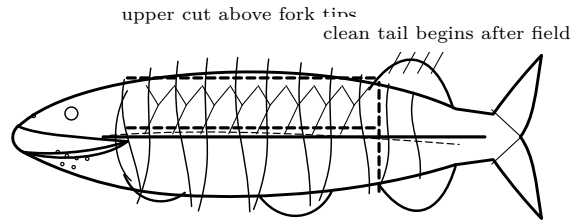
Parasites and raw fish

Freezing and pickling are not substitutes for a validated parasite-control process. Cook wild freshwater fish to an internal temperature of 145 °F, or until opaque and separating easily, unless following a qualified food-safety process. Discard abnormal-smelling or badly diseased flesh; when uncertain, do not eat it.

Species-specific first cuts

Because the fish is large, divide it: remove backstraps above ribs, tail slabs behind the Y-bone field, and side meat outside ribs. Keep the blade away from the gut; chill pieces as they come off.

Bone map and deboning



large front loins flank a discarded Y-bone channel; divide before final portioning

1. Keep the skin side down so the blade can ride on, not through, the bones.
2. Remove the rib cage with a shallow sweep, sacrificing as little belly meat as possible. Run fingertips both directions along every cut surface.
3. Y-bones fork through the upper front loin and do not pull cleanly. Trace their tips, cut a long channel above and below, and discard or stock the bony strip. Inspect each large chunk independently.
4. Portion only after a final fingertip inspection under a bright light. Bones become harder to locate once batter, crumbs, or sauce is added.

Trim map
Remove all skin, rib membrane, belly fat, and dark lateral meat. Separate the boneless tail from front loins before portioning; label and freeze excess promptly.

Prepare before heat

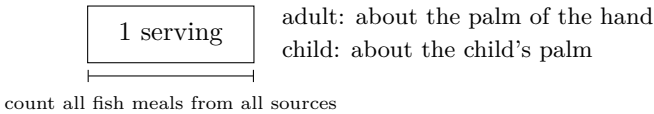
- Pat portions dry. Equal thickness matters more than equal weight.
- Cut thick loin into uniform medallions. Dry brine briefly to firm, then pat dry. Do not pickle as a substitute for cooking or validated parasite control.
- Refrigerate while the pan, oven, or grill heats. Marinate under refrigeration; discard marinade that contacted raw fish unless boiled.

Two dependable methods

Roasted musky loin
Roast uniform loin portions on a rack with mustard and herbs; verify 145 °F in the geometric center and rest briefly.
Firm-fish chowder
Poach boneless cubes gently in finished chowder until every cube reaches 145 °F; avoid a hard boil that tightens the flesh.

Current safe-eating advice · checked 2026-07-26

Statewide inland musky baseline: women under 50 and children under 15, do not eat; women 50+ and men, up to one serving/month. Check the exact lake query before any harvest meal.



THE QUERY BEATS THE PRINTED SHEET

Wisconsin has a statewide inland baseline and water-specific exceptions. Before eating, use DNR’s Fish Consumption Advisory Query for Pine Lake (WBIC 779200) or North Lake (WBIC 850800), and match species and length. People who are pregnant, may become pregnant, are breastfeeding, and children need the more protective category. When advice changes, follow the current query.

Sources. Wisconsin DNR Eating Your Catch and 2026–27 water-specific regulations; Wisconsin DHS Eat Fish Safely; USDA/FoodSafety.gov Safe Minimum Internal Temperature Chart; University of Minnesota Extension, Preserving Food at Home: Meat, Fish and Poultry. Cleaning sequence and monochrome diagrams are original editorial synthesis, checked 2026-07-26.

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